

POOR PRINT QUALITY COMPELS MRINAL SEN TO OPT OUT OF CANNES

KOLKATA | No Cannes Do

He made award-winning films in his heyday, but Mrinal Sen is not a happy man these days. The veteran filmmaker was invited to showcase his 1970s Calcutta trilogy *Interview*, *Calcutta 71* and *Padatik* between May 13 and 24 in Cannes, but had to pull out because the prints of his films were in bad condition. While the Sen family is trying to raise funds to restore some of the works, Sen himself rues that his films did not get the kind of care that those of his contemporary, the late Satyajit Ray, got. Ray's films are being restored by the Academy of Motion Pictures with funding from the Ford Foundation. "Perhaps my films will fade away when I leave," Sen was quoted as saying.

by Swagata Sen



47

is the number of Saravana Bhavan outlets P. Rajagopal owns.

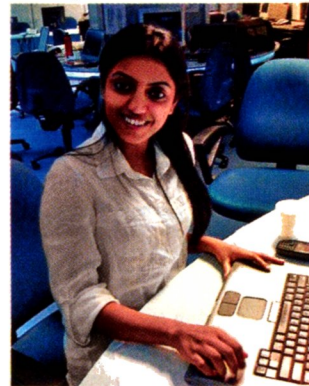
CHENNAI | Murder He Wrote

The Fritzs of the world are all being sentenced at the same time! In Chennai, it is the turn of P. Rajagopal, founder of the popular Saravana Bhavan chain of hotels and restaurants. The Madras High Court has sentenced him to life in a murder case. Earlier, a trial court had awarded him a 10-year rigorous imprisonment. He was convicted of killing Prince Shantakumar, an employee and husband of Jeevajyothi, who has complained of sexual harassment by Rajagopal. Rumours are rife that the 60-year-old Rajagopal wanted to marry Jeevajyothi, resulting in the murder of her husband.

by Nirmala Ravindran

Fear Factor

The murder of journalist Soumya Viswanathan last year and call centre employee Jigisha Ghose last week in Delhi and a slew of rapes and murders of BPO employees in Bangalore are proof that the working women are at high risk. Now, the arrest of a four-member gang by the Delhi Police shows just how vulnerable they are. The men not only confessed to killing Soumya and Jigisha, but also disclosed their modus operandi. They would wait for lone women driving back home from office, rob them and then Soumya Viswanathan



kill them. In a recent survey conducted by ASSOCHAM among working women in BPOs, IT firms, airlines, hospitals and media in leading metros in India, 65 and 56 per cent of the women interviewed in Delhi and Bangalore respectively felt unsafe working at night. Hopefully, the arrests mark a new beginning in the safety of working women.

by Mihir Srivastava

KOLKATA | Tram Makeover



KOLKATA MAY GET NEW, BETTER TRAMS

The much-derided trams of Kolkata, whose very existence is considered an aberration by many, are all set for a new avatar. The Transport Standing Committee's report has offered recommendations that are yet to be accepted by the West Bengal Assembly. Most of the 272 trams now plying in the city are more than half-a-century-old and the state has to bear a loss of Rs 1.2 crore annually for every tram, including the cost of spares brought from abroad. The committee feels it is time to make trams like those in other countries which will cost only Rs 20 lakh per car; at least 150 can be immediately remodelled. If the report is acted upon, the trams will not be an eyesore anymore but a good way to commute and a source of advertising revenue for the state Government.

by Abhijit Dasgupta